



BACK TO SCHOOL ANXIETY GUIDE



What to look for, what to say, and when to get more support.

1

Signs Your Child May Be Anxious

- Stomach aches or headaches with no medical cause.
- Clinginess or not wanting to separate.
- Sleep disturbances or nightmares.
- Increased meltdowns or irritability.
- Refusing to talk about school.
- Asking repeatedly “what if” questions.
- Regression to younger behaviours like thumb sucking or bedwetting.

2

What Actually Helps

- Validate feelings without minimizing — say “that makes sense—not “you’ll be fine.”
- Practice the school routine before it starts.
- Visit the school or classroom ahead of time if possible.
- Create a goodbye ritual that is consistent every day.
- Read books about starting school together.
- Focus on one small thing they are looking forward to.
- Limit your own anxiety in front of them — they co-regulate with you.
- Role play the school drop off at home so the routine feels familiar before it starts.

3

When to Seek More Support

Anxiety is interfering with sleep for more than two weeks.

Physical symptoms are frequent and escalating.

Child is refusing school completely.

You feel out of your depth and need guidance.

Talk to your family doctor or school social worker as a first step.

Parent note: Some anxiety about school is completely normal. Your calm presence is the most powerful tool you have.

You do not have to have all the answers. You just have to show up.